

Dome of the Rock

An important Islamic shrine with a sumptuous interior decorated with mosaics and tilework

Situated on the eastern side of the Old City of Jerusalem, the Dome of the Rock was completed in 691–692 CE by the Umayyad Caliph Abd al-Malik to protect and celebrate the great rock—known as the Foundation Stone—at its core. The shrine has huge religious significance for Muslims—it is the place where their prophet Muhammad began his momentous Night Journey of 621—and for Jews, who identify it as the site of their original Temple.

Intricate decoration

The building has a Byzantine-influenced, octagonal structure that was common in the eastern Mediterranean (see pp.252–253). Inside, two octagonal arcades create a double walkway around the great rock. The two walkways recall the circular movement of

pilgrims around the Kaaba in Mecca (see pp.282–283). Above the arches, much of the fine, original mosaic decoration has survived. The ornamental motifs, inspired by Byzantine and Sasanian models, are mostly based on plant forms, coiled around elaborate vases and jewels. The mosaics also feature inscriptions in kufic script, proclaiming messages of the Muslim faith.

The decorative elements of the building have been altered many times over the centuries. The most spectacular additions were executed in the Ottoman period during the reign of Suleyman the Magnificent (r.1520–1566). He commissioned the superb İznik tilework, which covers much of the exterior. Around 45,000 tiles were used. Suleyman's architects also redesigned the dome's 52 windows, filling the place with light.



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COLONNADES

The internal layout of the building was designed to focus attention on the great rock. The wooden dome is supported on a circular arcade of 12 columns and 4 piers. Around the rock, there is a double ambulatory (walkway), divided by an outer circuit of 16 columns and 8 piers.

